Share Our Wealth

Sen. Huey P. Long (D-LA) · national radio address · February 23, 1934 · excerpts

Source: Huey P. Long, 'Share Our Wealth' national radio address (Feb. 23, 1934), Congressional Record text via hueylong.com. Public domain.

Louisiana's flamboyant senator launched the Share Our Wealth Society from a radio studio in 1934 with the slogan 'Every Man a King.' Long proposed capping personal wealth at $5 million, guaranteeing every family a $5,000 'household estate,' and providing pensions, free college, and a 30-hour work week. By 1935 the society claimed 7.5 million members in 27,000 local clubs. Long was assassinated in September 1935 before he could mount a planned 1936 third-party challenge to FDR — but the pressure from his movement pushed FDR's 'Second New Deal' (Social Security, the Wagner Act, the Wealth Tax Act).

Connect: The Second New Deal (1935: Social Security, Wagner Act, Wealth Tax) was partly a response to pressure from Huey Long and others. Show how left-wing pressure moved FDR leftward.

Key Passages

The diagnosis

> We have in America today more wealth, more goods, more food, more clothing, more houses than we have ever had. We have everything in abundance here. We have the farm problem, my friends, because we have too much cotton, because we have too much wheat, and have too much corn, and too much potatoes.

'Every man a king'

> Now, we have organized a society, and we call it "Share Our Wealth Society," a society with the motto "Every Man a King." Every man a king, so there would be no such thing as a man or woman who did not have the necessities of life, who would not be dependent upon the whims and caprices and ipsi dixit of the financial barons for a living. What do we propose by this society? We propose to limit the wealth of big men in the country.

On the alphabet agencies

> You cannot solve these things through these various and sundry alphabetical codes. You can have the N. R. A. and P. W. A. and C. W. A. and the U. U. G. and G. I. N. and any other kind of dad-gummed lettered code. You can wait until doomsday and see 25 more alphabets, but that is not going to solve this proposition.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Depression; many Americans felt FDR's early New Deal had not done enough for the poor, as inequality and unemployment remained high.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary, struggling Americans listening on radio nationwide, especially the poor and working class who might join Share Our Wealth clubs.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Huey Long, a populist Louisiana senator and political rival of FDR, who used radical promises to build national support.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Complexity (1 pt): Argue both how Long PUSHED the New Deal leftward AND how he competed with FDR for the same voters.
2. Identify TWO specific New Deal measures of 1935 that responded to pressure from Long and other left critics.
3. Was Long a populist, a demagogue, or both? Defend your answer.

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> Louisiana's Senator Long proposed capping great fortunes and guaranteeing every family a basic share of the nation's wealth — a populist challenge from the left that pressured FDR to expand the New Deal.

Opening

It is not the difficulty of the problem which we have; it is the fact that the rich people of this country—and by rich people I mean the super-rich—will not allow us to solve the problems, or rather the one little problem that is afflicting this country, because in order to cure all of our woes it is necessary to scale down the big fortunes, that we may scatter the wealth to be shared by all of the people. . . . How many of you remember the first thing that the Declaration of Independence said? It said: "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that there are certain inalienable rights for the people, and among them are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness;" and it said further, "We hold the view that all men are created equal." Now, what did they mean by that? Did they mean, my friends, to say that all men are created equal and that that meant that any one man was born to inherit $10,000,000,000 and that another child was to be born to inherit nothing?

[. . .]

The diagnosis

We have in America today more wealth, more goods, more food, more clothing, more houses than we have ever had. We have everything in abundance here. We have the farm problem, my friends, because we have too much cotton, because we have too much wheat, and have too much corn, and too much potatoes. We have a home loan problem, because we have too many houses, and yet nobody can buy them and live in them. . . . So, we have in America today, my friends, a condition by which about 10 men dominate the means of activity in at least 85 percent of the activities that you own. They either own directly everything or they have got some kind of mortgage on it, with a very small percentage to be excepted.

[. . .]

The plan - 'Every Man a King'

Now, we have organized a society, and we call it "Share Our Wealth Society," a society with the motto "Every Man a King." Every man a king, so there would be no such thing as a man or woman who did not have the necessities of life, who would not be dependent upon the whims and caprices and ipsi dixit of the financial barons for a living. What do we propose by this society? We propose to limit the wealth of big men in the country. There is an average of $15,000 in wealth to every family in America. . . . We have to limit fortunes. Our present plan is that we will allow no one man to own more that $50,000,000. We think that with that limit we will be able to carry out the balance of the program. It may be necessary that we limit it to less than $50,000,000. . . . Another thing we propose is old-age pension of $30 a month for everyone that is 60 years old. Now, we do not give this pension to a man making $1,000 a year, and we do not give it to him if he has $10,000 in property, but outside of that we do. We will limit hours of work. . . . Those are the things we propose to do. "Every Man a King." Every man to eat when there is something to eat; all to wear something when there is something to wear. That makes us all a sovereign.

On the New Deal

You cannot solve these things through these various and sundry alphabetical codes. You can have the N. R. A. and P. W. A. and C. W. A. and the U. U. G. and G. I. N. and any other kind of dad-gummed lettered code. You can wait until doomsday and see 25 more alphabets, but that is not going to solve this proposition. . . . Now, my friends, we have got to hit the root

with the ax. Centralized power in the hands of a few, with centralized credit in the hands of a few, is the trouble. Get together in your community tonight or tomorrow and organize one of our Share Our Wealth Societies. If you do not understand it, write me and let me send you the platform; let me give you the proof of it.

Words to know

inalienable rights — rights that cannot be taken away

home loan problem — the wave of mortgage foreclosures during the Depression

ipsi dixit — the say-so of someone who gives no proof; here, bankers' arbitrary decisions

financial barons — the super-rich bankers and industrialists

alphabetical codes — New Deal agencies known by initials, such as the NRA and PWA

sovereign — one who rules; here, every citizen treated like a king